

1996: Hotmail!

March: Javascript Implemented In Netscape

Netscape Communications released JavaScript. Netscape Navigator 2 was the first browser to implement it. JavaScript allowed sites to be “dynamic,” or interactive, for the first time. This was possible because the JavaScript in the page could be executed at the client end in the browser without having to contact the server and reload the page. After the launch of JavaScript, websites sporting cursor trails and scrolling text became quite common; but there were many more serious uses as well, like checking the validity of an input before it was sent to the server, to save time and bandwidth. The language, when launched, was called Livescript, but since “Java” had become popular, and because they have somewhat similar code elements, the name was changed to JavaScript. It was standardised by the ECMA (European Computer Manufacturers Association) in the same year.

July: Hotmail Goes Live

Hotmail, founded by Jack Smith and Sabeer Bhatia, was officially launched. It was the first free Web-based e-mail provider, as opposed to ISP-offered e-mail, which was prevalent. The founders had met when they were employees at Apple Computer.

September: Thin Clients

The Network Computer (NC) concept was introduced by Oracle and Sun, among others. Intel and Microsoft did not support it, and quickly followed with the similar NetPC concept. Neither of these concepts were novel; they were similar to the older Thin Client concept. It envisaged a system of computing where a central server stored all data and applications and was connected to client PCs that did not have a hard disk. The client was called a Network Computer/NetPC. The advantages were that a user did not have to invest in expensive operating systems and application software for every client, and could access these from the central server when needed. Organisations were already implementing the Thin Client concept to save costs; the difference was that the Network